

“Satyagraha without constructive work is like a sentence without a verb.”

THE PROVOCATEUR

Unlike with most other leaders of the freedom struggle, 1947 did not signal an emeritus status for this man. Instead it meant continuing the fight for right. No surprise, then, that 12 of his 20 prison terms were in free India.

Ram Manohar Lohia

Freedom fighter 1910-1967

■ By Niranjan Ramakrishnan

The skill of a great leader”, wrote Ram Manohar Lohia, “lies in narrowing the numbers of those whom he angers and the duration of their anger. But anger them he must (and) risk his popularity with them...Mahatma Gandhi (did this). He had a calf, the child of the sacred cow, injected to death in a certain situation. He had a monkey shot, he took Harijans to temples, he refused to attend weddings unless they were inter-caste, he sanctioned divorce, he had the large sum of Rs 55 crore and more given to Pakistan at a time when Hindus held that treasonable, he acted and not spoke alone against property. In brief, he hardly ever missed doing anything that brought new life to the nation even if it brought calumny and danger to him.”

In this passage (from his 1958 essay, *Caste*), Lohia captured a little of the secret to the Gandhi magic, showing the chasm that separates the pristine from the merely pious. It was also a lesson Lohia took to heart—as his own incessant political and personal risk-taking would indicate; I read somewhere that he was imprisoned 20 times in his life of 57 years. Unlike with most other leaders of the freedom struggle, August 15, 1947, did not signal for Lohia (as it didn't for his comrade, Jayaprakash Narayan) an emeritus status from

